wanted to do that. The Democratic leader of the state senate burst into my office and said, “Giving that money back to the people is an unnecessary expenditure of public funds.”

In all, largely through property-tax relief, we returned more than $5 billion in taxes to the taxpayers—the people to whom it belonged in the first place.

It’s not easy for me to boast, but during the eight years, I think we made the state government less costly, smaller, and more businesslike; we were able to upgrade the quality of people attracted to government and cut the government’s growth to a rate at or below the level of California’s population growth; we made the bureaucracy more responsive to the public; and we began to return some of the power and taxing authority usurped by the state from local communities back to where they belonged, at the local level.

During the eight years, I used my line-item veto authority 943 times and was never overridden by the legislature. If a bill had something beneficial in it but legislators had voted too much money for it, I could sign the bill but cut spending to a reasonable level, allowing me to set priorities and enabling the state to live within its means. The power of the line-item veto is held by forty-three governors. How I would miss it later in Washington. Presidents don’t have a line-item veto.

Although many of my supporters wanted me to run for a third term in 1974, I’d accomplished most of what I’d set out to do and I’d sworn from the beginning that I was going to stop at two terms.

Nancy and I left Sacramento in early 1975. The previous eight years had changed both of us—and we had found a new love.